

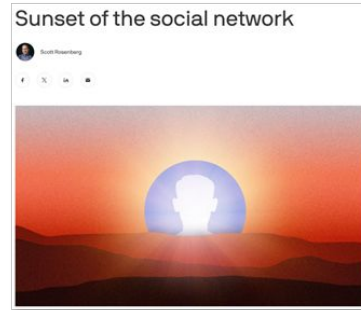
# Share this paper with a colleague to enhance their understanding of social media sharing practices

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# Research Context | Research Motivation | Research Method

- **Personalisation** as a dominant media **logic** (Kant, 2020) and principle of social organization (Lury and Day, 2019).
- Shift towards **content-centricity** (Kaye et al. 2022) and algorithm-user interaction over user-user (Su 2023) or creator-follower relationships (Abidin 2021).
- Research focussed on the notion of **self**, technology of **self** (Karakayali et al. 2017), algorithmized **self** (Bhandari and Bimo 2022), fragmentation of **self** (Lee et al. 2023).
- Concerns about **diminishing social qualities** (Gerbaudo 2024), echoing arguments on “lesser quality” of mediated sociality (Turkle 2011) and “phatic media culture” (Miller 2015).



*Axios 2021*



*Economist 2024*



*Mignano 2022*

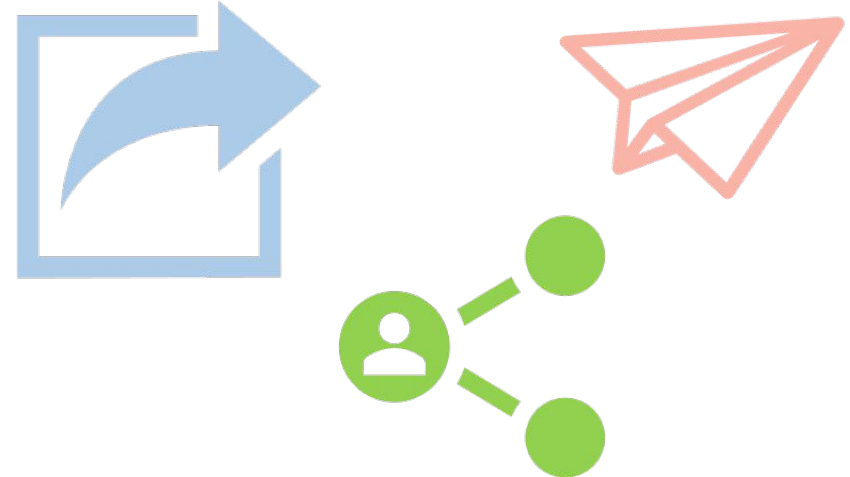


*Le Monde 2024*

# Research Context | Research Motivation | Research Method

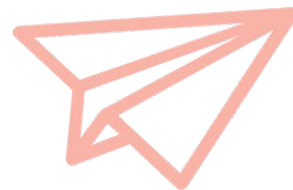
- **Defining social media** not through features but practices (Baym 2012, Madianou and Miller 2012).
- Exploring sharing as an integral to the **social praxis** of the internet (Baym 2012, John 2012, Kennedy 2016, Wittel 2011).
- In an increasingly content-centric and algorithm-driven landscape, focussing on the **cultural background work** of sharing practices today (John 2022).
- Understanding sharing practices as a form of **enacting algorithmic content** as part of local cultures and people's everyday lifeworlds (Siles 2023).
- Expanding on recent work showing the continued **appeal and vitality of sharing practices** (Campos Valverde 2022, McLean et al. 2023, Scharlach and Hallinan 2023, Schellewald 2024).

How can we make sense of the current social media age differently by (re-)focussing on the background work of sharing practices?



# Research Context | Research Motivation | Research Method

- Theories: **platform vernaculars** (Gibbs et al. 2015) + **phatic communication** (Carey 2009, Jakobson 1960, Malinowski 1923).
- **Digital ethnography** of Instagram Reels. **14 months** of fieldwork starting in late 2023.
- Focussed engagement with “share this” genre. **839 videos** of the genre through trained algorithm.
- **Thematic analysis** of videos as artefacts of the short-video sharing platform vernacular.



**381 million**

Likes across the  
collected videos

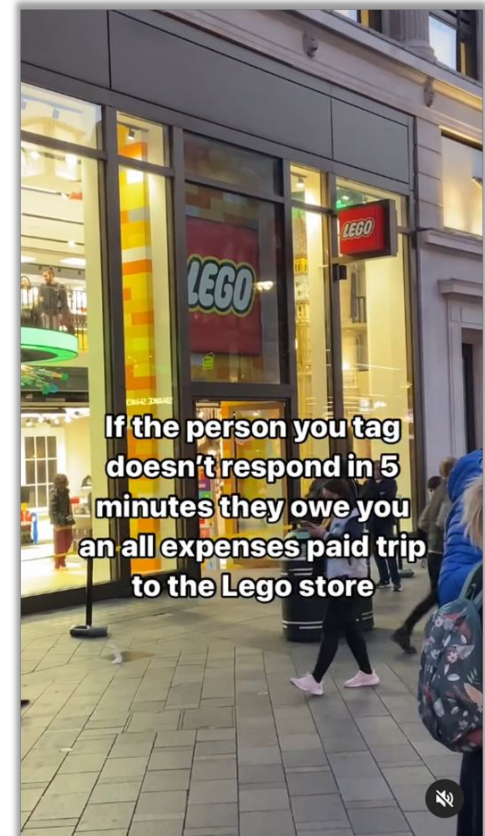
Romantic Affection | Appreciation | Indebtedness | Longing | Annoyance | Identification | Funny



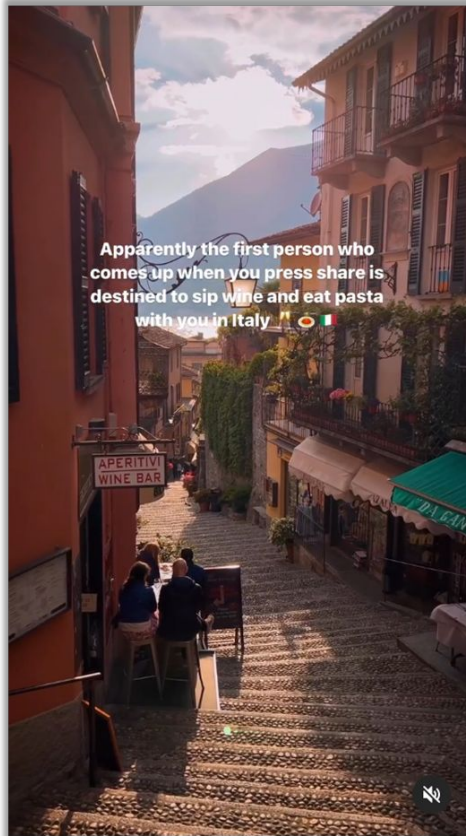
Romantic Affection | **Appreciation** | Indebtedness | Longing | Annoyance | Identification | Funny



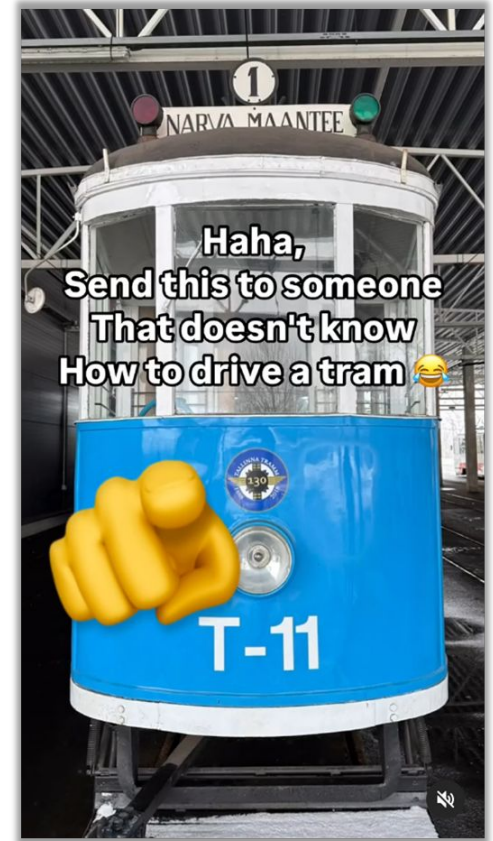


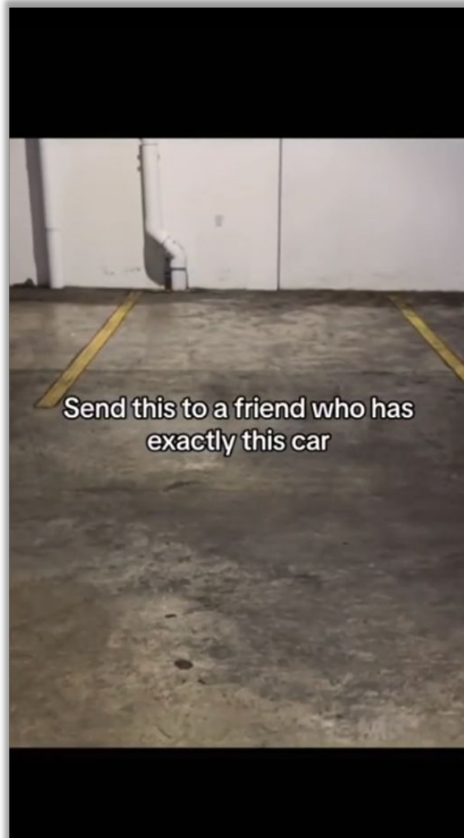


Romantic Affection | Appreciation | Indebtedness | **Longing** | Annoyance | Identification | Funny









Romantic Affection | Appreciation | Indebtedness | Longing | Annoyance | Identification | Funny

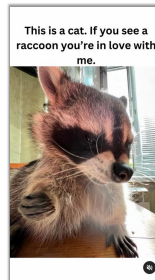
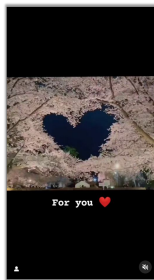


# Discussion - sketching the bigger picture

## The sharing vernacular mediates expressions of closeness

Various types of videos that enable the sender to reaffirm positive relationship qualities - for example, along the semantics of romantic affection, appreciation for the relationship, longing for shared time in the future, or light-hearted obligation and indebtedness that showcase the durability of social bond.

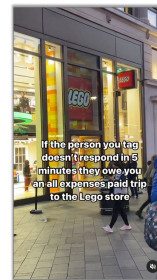
### Affection



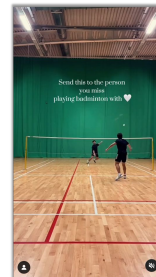
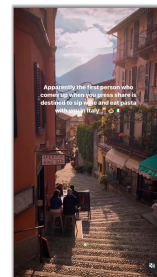
### Appreciation



### Indebtedness



### Longing



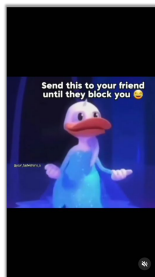


# Discussion - sketching the bigger picture

## The sharing vernacular enables forms of playful interaction and tease

Various types of videos that are a resource enabling people to engage in playful and humorous interaction, allowing to reaffirm the positionality of the other as equal (someone who can be teased and/or played with). For example, by sending content that is explicitly annoying or teasing.

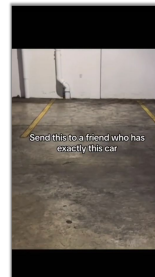
### Annoyance



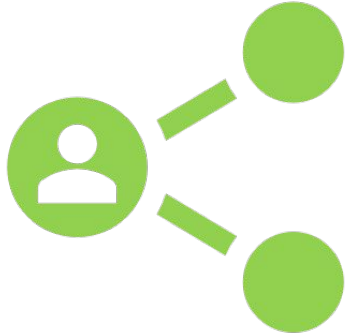
### Funny



### Identification



# Discussion - Atmosphere of sociability



## Relational maintenance

Content sharing practices closely position the self in relation to others within personalised media environments, e.g. in the role as friend (e.g., McLean 2023).



## Phatic communication

Sociability is achieved through phatic nature of communication, creating meaning in the form of interaction over the actual content (e.g., Simmel 1910).

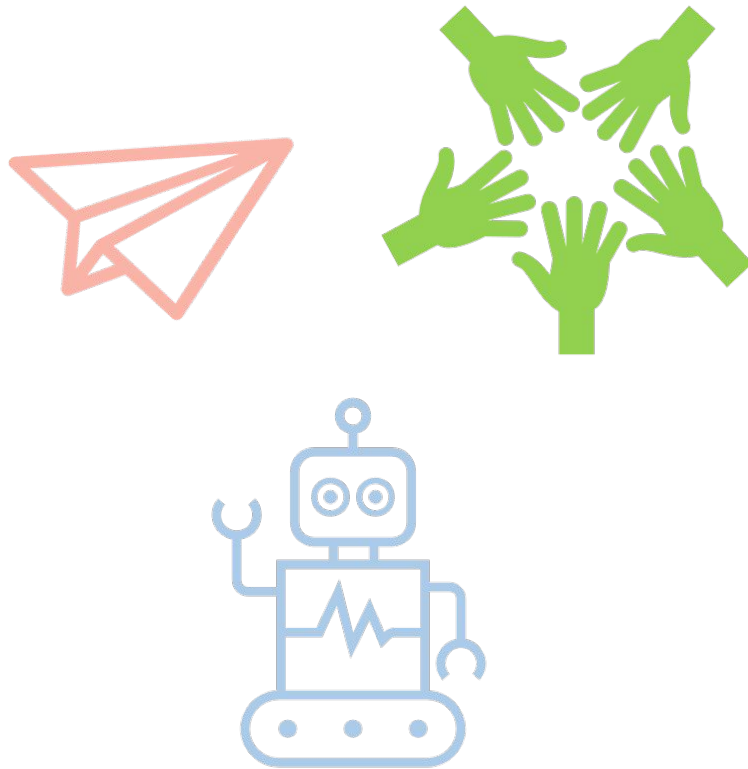


## Context awareness networking

Phatic communication is possible because content and interactions are embedded in interpersonal biographies, awareness for such (e.g., Ekman 2015).

# Conclusions - looking ahead

- Sharing practices and vernaculars allow us to see the **vibrant socialites** emerging in the background of personalised media environments.
- There are playful interaction with **algorithmic culture**, e.g., “share with top of your sharing list”, weaving algorithmic logics into everyday practices (Siles 2023).
- Sharing as a **self-reflexive practice**, at times thematized in content itself for the limits of this kind of social interaction.
- **Limitations and future research:**
  - Cross-cultural and comparative generational research on sharing practices.
  - Implications and relevance for questions of public culture and communication.
  - Commercial logics and historical parallels (e.g., greetings cards, see West 2008).



# Thanks!

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